

Petauroides volans

Greater glider



Length 14–19 in
(35–48 cm)
Tail 18–23½ in
(45–60 cm)
Weight 2–3½ lb
(0.9–1.5 kg)
Location E. Australia
Social unit Pair
Status Vulnerable



Groups of scratch marks on tree trunks betray regular landing sites of the greater glider, the largest gliding marsupial. Like other tree-dwelling marsupials, it has sharp claws to grip bark, and 2 toes on the front foot oppose the other 3, giving a pincerlike grip.



furred gliding membrane between elbow and rear foot

underparts off-white in both color phases

non-prehensile tail used for steering during glides

FACING THE FRONT



The greater glider's large eyes and huge ears face the front, so it can judge distances accurately by stereoscopic vision and stereophonic sound. This enables the glider to parachute horizontal distances of more than 330 ft (100 m) at night and yet land precisely on a tree trunk.

COLOR PHASES
The greater glider occurs in 2 color forms or phases, often in the same area. One is charcoal-gray to black, tinged with brown (as seen here); the other is very pale gray or mottled cream.

Distoechurus pennatus

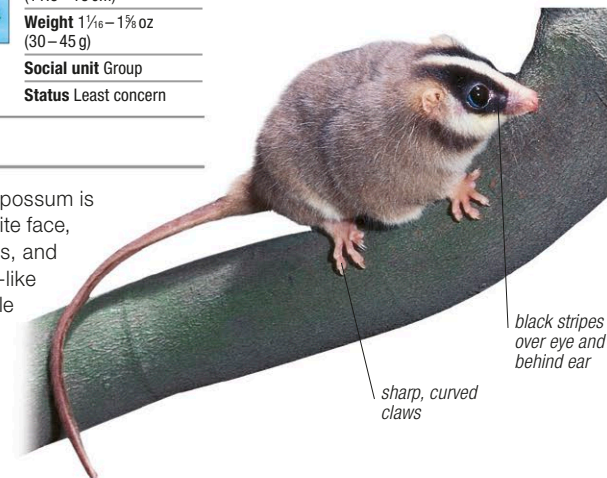
Feather-tailed possum



Length 3½–4¼ in
(9–11 cm)
Tail 4½–6 in
(11.5–15 cm)
Weight 1½–1¾ oz
(30–45 g)
Location New Guinea
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The feather-tailed possum is identified by its white face, with 4 black stripes, and its feather- or quill-like tail with a prehensile tip. It moves through the tree branches by darting leaps,



black stripes over eye and behind ear

sharp, curved claws

gripping with the sharp claws on all toes, and consumes insects (especially cicadas), as well as flowers, nectar, and fruit. These possums appear to live in groups of 2–3, and the female carries 1–2 young in her pouch, then riding on her back near the nest. Details of the social and breeding habits are, however, lacking.

Cercartetus lepidus

Little pygmy-possum



Length 2–2¼ in
(5–6.5 cm)
Tail 2½–3 in
(6–7.5 cm)
Weight ¾–1½ oz
(5–9 g)
Location S.E. Australia, Tasmania
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern





The smallest possum species, with a thumb-sized body, this is the only pygmy-possum with gray fur on the underside; the upperparts are fawn or brown. It has a short, blunt face and large, erect ears. The prehensile tail can support the animal's entire weight, and expands at its base to store excess food as fat. Nocturnal and usually solitary, this marsupial feeds in low bushes and shrubs, or on the ground, on a variety of small animals from insects to lizards.

Hypsiprymnodon moschatus

Musky rat-kangaroo



Length 6½–11 in
(16–28 cm)
Tail 4¾–7 in
(12–17 cm)
Weight 13–24 oz
(375–675 g)
Location N.E. Australia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern





Neither rat nor kangaroo, this is a potoroid marsupial (see right). Its preferred habitat is thick rain forest. It forages alone by day, mainly on the ground for fallen fruit such as figs, as well as palm nuts, seeds, and fungi. It also hoards food at scattered sites—unusual behavior among marsupials—and bounds on all fours, gripping with the opposable big toe on each rear foot. Both sexes produce a musky odor, particularly during breeding.

Acrobates pygmaeus

Pygmy glider



Length 2¼–3 in
(6.5–8 cm)
Tail 2¼–3 in
(7–8 cm)
Weight 1½–¾ oz
(9–15 g)
Location E. Australia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Also called the feather-tailed glider, this tiny, agile marsupial has a long tail with a row of stiff hairs on either side. The gliding membrane extends between the front and rear limbs, and the “dual-purpose” toes have sharp claws to dig into bark. Expanded, padlike tips on the toes grip smooth, shiny surfaces such as leaves—even glass windows. The tongue is long and brush-tipped, to gather nectar, pollen, and small insects from flowers.



Potorous longipes

Long-footed potoroo



Length 15–16½ in
(38–42 cm)
Tail 12–13 in
(30–33 cm)
Weight 3¼–5 lb
(1.6–2.2 kg)
Location S.E. Australia
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



This potoroo (“rat-kangaroo”) is an active, solitary, nocturnal fungus-eater. It bounds at high speed, kangaroolike, on its large back feet, and scrabbles for food with the shorter but strong front limbs. Some 30 fungus species make up four-fifths of its diet. It also eats insects and green plant matter. After an incubation period of 38 days, the single young suckles in the pouch for up to 5 months, and remains with its mother for a further 2–3 months.

